Ashoka's dhamma, ceasing to kill animals being central to the emperor's concerns. Moreover, rather than anything that relates to gods, dhamma is a moral order involving humans and their roles in that order. In the early edicts of Karnataka it occurs in association with the Buddhist virtues ('dhamma-guna') which were to be practised. So, what the north-western people of the empire made of eusebeia seems worth thinking about. The interpretive outcome of using a language to transmit a message culturally grounded elsewhere will have modified the meaning of the message, at points perhaps crucially enough to seriously puzzle people.

What of the other epigraph in Aramaic inscribed below the Greek? This too uses words more at home within a culture rooted in the West rather than in the subcontinent. The Aramaic is not an exact translation of the Greek but corresponds in its general character to that text inasmuch as Ashoka's spiritual success is the main thrust of it:

> 10 years [having] fallen [it] was made which [was that] our Lord Prydrs, the king, promoted Truth (*Qsyt'*). Since then evil has diminished for all men, and he has caused all hostile things to disappear, and joy has arisen throughout the whole earth. And moreover, there is this (?): for the feeding of our Lord, the king, little is killed; seeing this (?) all men have given up [killing animals], and those who caught fishes, those men have given up [doing it]; similarly, those who are without restraint (?) have ceased to be without restraint (?). And [there is] good obedience to one's mother and father and to the old people, as destiny has laid down on every one. And there is no judgment for all men [who are] pious. This has benefited all men and will continue to benefit.[30]

Line by line, the Aramaic phrases do not correspond with the Greek. The differences are worth highlighting. The king here 'promotes truth' ('qshyt' in Aramaic) while in the Greek he makes known his doctrine of 'piety'. Unlike the king who abstained from killing in the Greek inscription, here 'for the feeding of Our Lord the king, little is killed'. Presumably, this meant that hardly any animals were being slaughtered for the royal kitchen. This reduction apparently encouraged his subjects to give up the killing of animals—or so the epigraph says. The declaration's end—'And there is no